



Shock exits

12 seeds were upset in the first round, most notably No. 3 Alexander Zverev, No. 7 and 2024 semifinalist Lorenzo Musetti, No. 8 Holger Rune, and No. 9 Daniil Medvedev.

Novak Djokovic, the last of the legendary Big Three, viewed this Wimbledon as his last best chance to capture a 25th Grand Slam title.

Already the undisputed GOAT, with two more Majors than second-place Rafael Nadal along with a gold medal at the 2024 Paris Olympics, Djokovic knew the odds were stacked against him. Like all the contenders, he'd most likely have to beat both Sinner and Alcaraz.

But first, Djokovic had to take care of business against 22nd-seeded Flavio Cobolli. The 23-year-old Italian, thrilled about the most memorable run of his young career, posted "*Me versus my idol*" on social media. The idol prevailed 6-7(6), 6-2, 7-5, 6-4, but it was a Pyrrhic victory. Sadly, on his second match point, Djokovic slipped and fell on the slick grass, injuring his hip. Grimacing in pain, he recovered enough to win the next two points. It was a small consolation that the triumph earned a 14th Wimbledon semifinal and 52nd Major semifinal, both of which are records.

Afterwards, Djokovic said, "Great performance from him. He was playing on a really high level. I think what surprised me a lot is his serve. He was serving at a really fast pace and going for his shots. He's such a talented and skilful player."

Djokovic's quest for an eighth Wimbledon title ended against Sinner, who Patrick McEnroe described as "a younger, more powerful version of Djokovic." Sinner was also healthier, as his elbow had recovered, while Djokovic's movement was compromised by his injured hip.

Aside from a short-lived 3-0 lead in the third set, neither his vast experience nor chants of "Nole! Nole" could save Djokovic during his decisive 6-3, 6-3, 6-4 defeat. When the GOAT didn't run for a backhand crosscourt winner, Patrick said, "It's painful for him, and it's painful for us to watch." Djokovic waved to the cheering crowd as he exited Centre Court. Later, he said he didn't think this was his last Wimbledon.

Rising star: Taylor Fritz put up an impressive fight against Alcaraz in the other semifinal. AP

As for the Big Two, Sinner and Alcaraz have claimed the last seven Majors, relishing and thriving on their growing rivalry.

"Champions learn from... I'm not going to say their failures, but they learn from their losses," said Alcaraz. "I knew he was going to learn from the French Open final and not make the same mistakes. That he was able to get over that so quickly and win here didn't surprise me at all. The way he played today was really high, and he knew he was going to play like this. I know he's a really nice player and a huge champion."

Alcaraz continued, "I am really happy about having this rivalry with him. It's great for us, and it's great for tennis. Every time we play against each other, I think our level is really high. I don't see any other players having the level we do when we face each other."